

Atelopus zeteki

Golden frog



Location S. Central America (Panama)

Length 1½–2¼ in (3.5–6 cm)

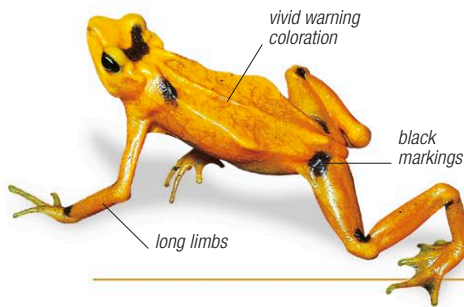
Habit Mostly terrestrial

Breeding Rainy season season

Status Critically endangered



This vivid yellow or orange toad, sometimes with black markings, provides a good example of warning coloration. Its skin produces poison when it is attacked and predators learn to avoid it, having experienced the pain once, associating bright color with a noxious stimulus. Like many frogs and toads living in Central America, its numbers have declined drastically in recent years.

*Brachycephalus ephippium*

Spix's saddleback toad



Location E. South America

Length ¾–¾ in (1–2 cm)

Habit Mostly terrestrial

Breeding Not recorded season

Status Least concern



Also known as the gold frog, this species is an inhabitant of mountain rain forest, where it lives mainly among leaf litter, preying on insects and other small invertebrates. During dry spells, it hides in crevices. The Spix's saddleback toad is a ground dweller—it cannot jump, nor can it climb well, because its stubby toes lack adhesive disks. It has a saddlelike, bony plate embedded in the smooth skin of its back, and is bright orange above, with a yellow underside. The female lays 5 or 6 large eggs on land; there is no tadpole stage, the eggs hatching directly into small frogs.

Nimbaphrynoides occidentalis

Western Nimba toad



Location W. Africa (Mount Nimba)

Length ½–1 in (1.5–2.5 cm)

Habit Wholly terrestrial

Breeding Spring and summer season

Status Critically endangered



This toad has a highly unusual mode of reproduction: the eggs are fertilized and the young develop inside the mother. After a 9-month gestation period, she gives birth by inflating herself with air and pushing out 2–16 tiny toadlets. The western Nimba toad hides in rocky crevices in the dry season.

Rhinoderma darwinii

Darwin's frog



Location S. South America

Length 1–1¼ in (2.5–3 cm)

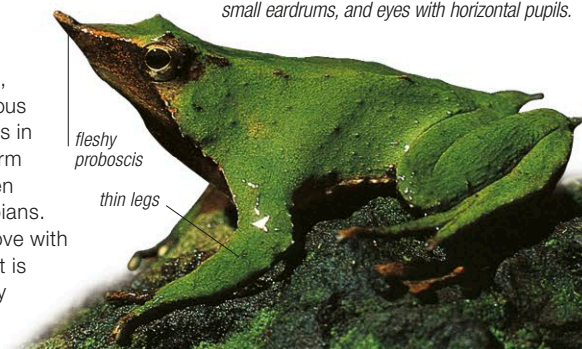
Habit Mostly terrestrial

Breeding Year round season

Status Vulnerable



An inhabitant of mountain forest in the southern Andes, Darwin's frog is famous for brooding its eggs in its vocal sacs—a form of parental care seen in few other amphibians. Brown or green above with a black underside, it is easily recognized by its small size and sharply pointed

*Pedostibes hosii*

Boulenger's Asian tree toad



Location S.E. Asia

Length 2–4 in (5–10 cm)

Habit Mostly terrestrial

Breeding Rainy season season

Status Least concern



Unusually for a toad, Boulenger's Asian tree toad is a good climber, with adhesive disks on all its toes. It has warts and small spines on its skin, and varies in color from greenish brown to black, with yellow spots; some females also have a purple tinge. It is usually found along rivers and streams in

forest, and is active at night, feeding on ants. The female lays numerous small eggs in strings in flowing water. The tadpoles have suckerlike mouths that enable them to cling to rocks.



PARENTAL CARE



After a female Darwin's frog has deposited a clump of up to 40 large eggs on the ground, the male guards them for 2–3 weeks. When the embryos begin to move, he swallows up to 15 eggs and retains them in his vocal sacs, where they hatch into tadpoles. The tadpoles require only their own egg yolk in order to develop into froglets. These then emerge from the father's mouth.

Pseudis paradoxa

Paradoxical frog



Location N. and C. South America

Length 2–2¼ in (5–7 cm)

Habit Wholly aquatic

Breeding Rainy season season

Status Least concern



In most frogs, adults are considerably larger than mature tadpoles, but in this species the situation is reversed. Paradoxical frog tadpoles have an unusually long life, and can grow up to 10 in (25 cm) long—about 4 times longer than the adult frog. During the final stage of metamorphosis, the animal shrinks, largely by absorbing its very long tail. Most of the features of the adult frog

are adaptations for a highly aquatic lifestyle: it has upward-pointing eyes and nostrils that enable it to float just beneath the water's surface, fully webbed hind feet for swimming, and slimy skin.

